NCAI Climate Action Task Force: A Brief History

The NCAI Climate Action Task Force (CATF) was established in February 2019 by NCAI President Jefferson Keel to unify Tribal climate advocacy under one coordinated body. The Task Force brought together Tribal leaders from Alaska, the Northeast, the Pacific Northwest, and the Southwest to document Tribal climate action, develop consensus policy priorities, and advocate for federal funding. Over five years, the CATF produced major policy reviews, secured Tribal representation at the White House and UN climate summits, and helped shape hundreds of millions of dollars in federal climate resilience investments for Indian Country. This report compiles every verifiable detail about its founding, membership, principles, work, and the specific NCAI resolutions that form its policy backbone.

The Task Force launched in early 2019 after years of groundwork

NCAI President Jefferson Keel (Lt. Governor, Chickasaw Nation) formally announced the Climate Action Task Force at NCAI's Executive Council Winter Session in February 2019. One NCAI press release from November 2020 dates the establishment to "2018," which likely reflects preliminary planning and conceptual groundwork in late 2018 before the public announcement. Alongside the CATF, Keel launched the NCAI Climate Action Resource Center, an online hub designed to connect Tribal Leaders, natural resource managers, and climate scientists with data and tools.

The official working mission statement, as announced by President Keel: "Document, inform, and support the climate action efforts of Tribal nations and Native organizations, and identify and advocate for policies and funding designed to empower their ability to engage in effective, sustainable climate action." The CATF was also tasked with developing and advocating for consensus-based policy priorities, and with documenting and sharing successful Tribal climate action initiatives across Indian Country. The NCAI staff lead was Ian Record, Director of the Partnership for Tribal Governance.

Formation moved quickly from there. In March 2019, NCAI distributed a public survey to Indian Country stakeholders soliciting input on CATF priorities and composition. On June 20, 2019, NCAI announced the appointment of four inaugural co-chairs, and the inaugural CATF meeting followed on June 24, 2019 at NCAI's Mid-Year Conference in Reno, Nevada. A formal "Mission and Functions" document was published on September 30, 2019.

Worth noting: the CATF was established through a presidential initiative rather than through the standard NCAI resolution process. No resolution number authorizing its creation has been identified.

Four Directions: Representing Alaska, the Northeast, Northwest, and Southwest

The CATF was designed with geographic breadth in mind. The **four inaugural co-chairs**, announced June 20, 2019, were:

- **Melanie Bahnke** | President, Kawerak, Inc. (Bering Strait region, Alaska). Kawerak is an Alaska Native regional nonprofit serving 20 Tribal communities.
- **Brian Cladoosby** | Chairman, Swinomish Indian Tribal Community (Washington State). Cladoosby also served as NCAI President from 2013–2017 and championed the Paris Agreement resolution.
- **Stephen Roe Lewis** | Governor, Gila River Indian Community (Arizona). Lewis participated in a February 2020 Congressional Select Committee on the Climate Crisis roundtable while serving as co-chair.
- **Beverly Cook** | Tribal Chief, Saint Regis Mohawk Tribe (Akwesasne, New York). Cook stated at the founding: *"Indian Country is comprised of place-based people who recognize that climate change is one of the most critical threats we face today to traditional ways of life."*

President Keel said of the co-chairs: *"These leaders oversee cutting-edge initiatives that work to mitigate and adapt to the impacts of climate change on Native communities. They bring a wealth of knowledge to the Task Force, and will serve as able stewards as the Task Force commences its critical work on this grave challenge to our peoples, places, cultures, and economies."*

By **November 2020**, the co-chair roster had shifted. **Leonard Forsman**, Chairman of the Suquamish Tribe and President of the Affiliated Tribes of Northwest Indians (ATNI), replaced Cladoosby and Lewis. The co-chairs at that point were Bahnke, Cook, and Forsman. Forsman went on to testify before the Senate Committee on Indian Affairs in February 2021 in his capacity as CATF co-chair.

The CATF's **Technical Committee comprised 22 members**: **12 regional technical experts** (one from each of NCAI's 12 regions), **6 at-large representatives** addressing Tribal climate action at national and international levels, **2 Native elder representatives**, and **2 Native youth representatives**. One youth member has been publicly identified: **Sam Schimmel**, an Alaska Native youth (per Charkoosta.com reporting). Individual names of most Technical Committee members were not made publicly available. Under NCAI President **Fawn Sharp** (Quinault Indian Nation, 2019–2023), climate action became a signature priority of her presidency. Sharp was succeeded by **Mark Macarro** (Pechanga Band of Luiseño Indians) in November 2023; as Indian Country faces compounding crises and high-priority attention, climate work has been less prominent in the regular NCAI agenda. Nonetheless, the CATF working sessions and page remains listed under NCAI Initiatives. The necessity for coordinated climate action to support Tribal Sovereignty and the wellbeing of Tribal communities remains however, and it is critical to understand the history of the CATF to move forward in a meaningful way to address this challenge.

In Service to Tribal Nations: Guiding Principles

The CATF operates within a principled framework that merges Indigenous governance traditions with modern climate science and policy. Six core principles define its work:

- **Tribal Sovereignty:** Climate action must be self-governed, with Tribal nations crafting their own approaches. Federal and international frameworks should empower, not dictate.
- **Federal Trust and Treaty Responsibility:** The U.S. government has fiduciary obligations to protect the ecosystems on which Tribal communities depend. Climate impacts to treaty-protected resources trigger federal action obligations.
- **Traditional Ecological Knowledge (TEK):** NCAI describes Tribal knowledge as *"time-tested, climate resilient, sustainable, and cost-effective."* Integration of TEK into all climate responses is a foundational requirement, not an optional add-on.
- **Free, prior, and informed consent (FPIC):** Tribal nations must be consulted under this international standard, codified in the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP), for any climate actions affecting their lands, resources, or communities.
- **Place-based Identity:** Indian Country comprises place-based peoples for whom environmental disruption threatens not only livelihoods but cultural survival, spiritual practices, and intergenerational knowledge systems.
- **Planning for Seven Generations:** Actions must consider impacts on *"seven generations to come,"* as referenced by NCAI leadership including former President Brian Cladoosby.

The CATF's six operational goals flow from these principles: **(1) document** Tribal climate action efforts; **(2) inform** Tribal Nations about climate impacts, policies, and funding; **(3) support** Tribal climate initiatives; **(4) identify** and advocate for empowering policies and funding; **(5) develop** consensus-based policy priorities; and **(6) ensure** Tribal nations have an equal seat at national and international climate action tables.

NCAI Resolutions and Policy Support Climate Action

NCAI's policy positions are established through consensus-based resolutions adopted at Annual Conventions, Mid-Year Conferences, and Executive Council Winter Sessions. The NCAI resolution process is one of the most powerful expressions of collective Tribal governance in federal Indian policy. When Tribal Nations bring a climate resolution to the floor and it is adopted by consensus, it carries the weight of Indian Country speaking with one voice. Over the past two decades, NCAI has built a sustained body of climate resolutions that reflect what Tribal Nations have recognized long before the broader policy world caught up: that climate change is not an environmental issue alone, but a direct threat to Treaty rights, trust responsibilities, homelands, and the wellbeing of future generations. These resolutions have called for full federal consultation on climate impacts, defended international climate commitments when the federal government stepped back from them, opposed extractive development that threatens Tribal waters and sacred sites, and demanded that Indigenous Knowledge holders be recognized as leaders in global climate governance. Each resolution represents not just a policy position but a collective commitment, one Nation standing with another to protect what matters to all.

Resolution #PHX-16-058 (2016): *"United States Federal Agency Consultation, Consent, Funding, and Actions to Address Climate Change Impacts to Tribal Treaty and Trust Resources."* Adopted at the Annual Convention in Phoenix, this resolution urged federal agencies to engage with individual Tribes on a government-to-government basis on climate issues. It called on Congress to identify the full costs facing Tribes from climate change and proposed establishing a National Tribal Climate Change Workgroup. The resolution noted that in FY2016, DOI's Tribal Climate Resilience Program awarded only **$8.6 million** against **$25.5 million** in Tribal requests, a nearly 3:1 funding gap.

Resolution #MOH-17-053 (2017): ***"Continued Support for the Paris Climate Agreement and Action to Address Climate Change."*** Adopted **unanimously** at the Mid-Year Conference (Mohegan Sun, Uncasville, CT) following President Trump's June 2017 announcement of intent to withdraw from the Paris Agreement. This landmark resolution committed NCAI to supporting initiatives for renewable energy investment, energy efficiency, public education on climate impacts in Indian Country, greenhouse gas reduction, and climate resiliency. Then-President Brian Cladoosby stated: *"The Paris Climate Agreement is an important step toward a better future for our seven generations to come."* NCAI and the Native American Rights Fund (NARF) also issued a joint statement declaring they *"remain firmly committed to representing and advancing Indigenous peoples' interests in the ongoing process of implementing the Agreement."*

Resolution #DEN-18-047 (2018): ***"Opposing Offshore Drilling."*** Adopted at the Annual Convention in Denver. Opposed any proposal to open Pacific Northwest oceans to offshore drilling, called on the federal government to fulfill its trust obligation by continuing the moratorium, and demanded direct consultation with each affected Tribe.

Resolution #DEN-18-061 (2018): ***"Opposition to Construction of Keystone XL Pipeline and the Use of Excessive Force or Private Security to Suppress Free Speech."*** Also adopted at the Denver Annual Convention. This built on an earlier resolution (MKE-11-030 from 2011) and supported Tribal nations' efforts to protect lands, waters, sacred sites, and ways of life. After Biden revoked the Keystone XL permit on January 20, 2021, NCAI explicitly cited this resolution in its commendation statement.

2018 Mid-Year Resolution: ***"Implementation of the Indigenous Peoples' Traditional Knowledge Platform within the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change."*** Adopted at the Mid-Year Session in Kansas City (June 3–6, 2018). Called on UNFCCC parties to support full and effective participation of Indigenous Peoples, with traditional knowledge holders in equal-status leadership positions. Committed NCAI to working with the International Indigenous Peoples' Forum on Climate Change (IIPFCC). The exact resolution number could not be confirmed from available sources.

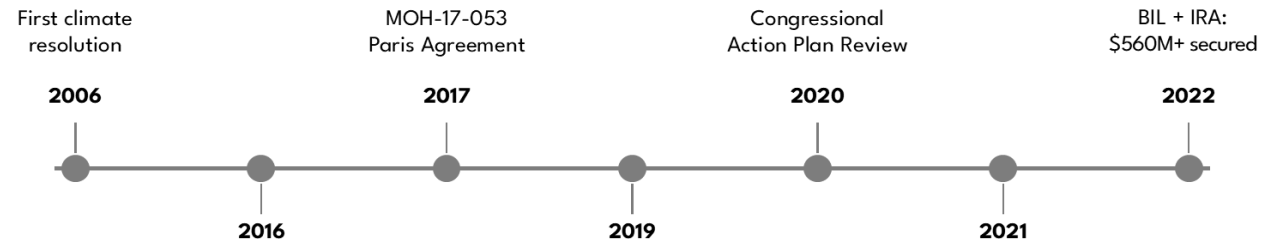
Resolution #ABQ-19-032 (2019): ***"Calling on the Department of Interior to Adopt Tribal Energy Resource Agreement Regulations That Respect Tribal Sovereignty and Self-Determination."*** Adopted at the Annual Convention in Albuquerque. This resolution on Tribal energy self-determination was cited in the **Fifth National Climate Assessment (NCA5)**, Chapter 16 on Tribes and Indigenous Peoples.

Additional climate-adjacent resolutions include **Resolution #TUL-13-021 (2013)** on energy affordability through weatherization and renewable systems, which documented that energy costs in rural Alaska reach **$1/kWh** and heating oil **$7/gallon** with rural households spending **47% of income** on home energy; **Resolution #MKE-11-030 (2011)** calling for reduced reliance on tar sands oil and a transition to cleaner energy solutions; a **2007 Annual Convention resolution** supporting S. 2076, the Clean Renewable Energy and Economic Development Act; and a **2006 Winter Session resolution** calling for a mandatory program to reduce climate change pollution and promote renewable energy, representing one of NCAI's earliest climate-specific actions.

What makes this body of work remarkable is its consistency and its reach. From energy sovereignty and affordable clean energy in some of the most underserved communities in the country, to opposition to pipeline construction that threatens Tribal lands, to formal engagement with the United Nations climate framework, these resolutions demonstrate that Tribal Nations have been leading on climate action across every scale of governance for nearly twenty years. The resolution process itself is the mechanism through which that leadership becomes collective. It transforms individual Tribal priorities into shared positions that carry political and moral authority in Congressional hearings, federal rulemaking, and international negotiations. It is governance in practice, rooted in the understanding that when Tribal Nations align around common purpose, the impact extends far beyond any single community; these actions benefit all of Indian Country, and ultimately, benefits everyone and the generations to come.

Climate Action Through Collective Sovereignty: The Legacy of the NCAI Climate Action Task Force

The Climate Action Task Force has consistently demonstrated that Tribal Nations are not passive recipients of climate policy but active leaders in affecting climate policy and areas of focus. Through strategic publications, Congressional testimony, international diplomacy, and convenings that center Indigenous Knowledge and Tribal sovereignty, the CATF has shaped climate discourse at every level of governance. From providing Tribal leaders with actionable frameworks for engaging federal legislation, to securing unprecedented Indigenous representation in global climate negotiations, to lifting up Tribal climate innovations as models for the broader field, the CATF has built a track record of translating Tribal priorities into policy influence. This work has been grounded in broad Tribal participation and carried forward through partnerships across Indian Country, ensuring that the voices shaping climate action reflect the Nations most impacted by and most prepared to lead through the climate crisis.



The CATF's output spans congressional testimony, major policy publications, international diplomacy, and federal funding advocacy.

Advocacy as a key component of the CATF has occurred through NCAI's submission of **formal comments to the U.S. Senate on Climate Change/Action in Indian Country (September 2019)**, participation in the **Congressional Select Committee on the Climate Crisis roundtable (February 2020)**, joining the **"We Are Still In" Declaration** supporting Paris Agreement commitments, and the Climate Action Resource Center's ongoing curation of Tribal climate adaptation plans and data resources. On February 24, 2021, Leonard Forsman testified before the U.S. Senate Committee on Indian Affairs[1] on Tribal priorities and climate-related challenges. In this testimony, he highlighted the Swinomish Indian Tribal Community's revival of traditional clam gardens as an adaptation strategy addressing ocean acidification. He also cited the Navajo Nation's Kayenta Solar Project, which at the height of construction[2] powering **36,000 homes** and creating **284 jobs**, and Blue Lake Rancheria's zero-carbon microgrid.

[1]U.S. Senate Committee on Indian Affairs (2021) Testimony of Leonard Forsman, February 24, 2021. https://www.indian.senate.gov/wp-content/uploads/20210224%20ATNI%20Forsman%20Testimony%20Senate%20Committee%20on%20Indian%20Affairs.pdf
[2]U.S. Department of Energy (2018) Kayenta Solar Project Overview. https://www.energy.gov/sites/prod/files/2018/10/f56/steiger-wapa.pdf

The Tribal Review of the Congressional Action Plan on the Climate Crisis[3] stands as the CATF's most significant publication. Produced in November 2020 by leadership from the National Congress of American Indians and the Affiliated Tribes of Northwest Indians, the InterTribal Review examined the House Select Committee on the Climate Crisis's 2020 Congressional Action Plan, *Solving the Climate Crisis: The Congressional Action Plan for a Clean Energy Economy and a Healthy, Resilient, and Just America*. The document provides a Tribal-centered analysis of the plan's twelve pillars, offering strategic frameworks, draft advocacy language, and an assessment of policy gaps and opportunities, informed by contributions from 106 participants representing 97 Tribal Nations, organizations, and agencies gathered through a National Tribal and Indigenous Climate Conference.

At the international level, NCAI issued a formal statement emphasizing that *"solutions cannot be developed without continued and increased Indigenous participation and inclusion."* In November 2021 at the UN Climate Change Conference (COP26) in Glasgow, Fawn Sharp received diplomatic credentials from the U.S. Department of State. She was described as the first Tribal leader s to receive formal U.S. diplomatic recognition at a UN climate conference[4]. On April 22, 2021, Sharp participated in the White House Leaders Summit on Climate[5], joining world leaders in a breakout session titled Climate Action at All Levels, moderated by EPA Administrator Michael S. Regan. In January 2023, Sharp participated in the World Economic Forum Annual Meeting in Davos as a panelist in the session Leading the Charge Through Earth's New Normal[6].

The CATF's advocacy contributed to tangible federal investment outcomes. Recent federal legislation and agency actions have slightly reduced investment in Tribal climate resilience and adaptation, but available funding remains substantially below the level estimated by the Bureau of Indian Affairs to meet long-term Tribal infrastructure relocation needs driven by climate change. Federal investment in Tribal climate resilience increased under the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law[7], which directed $466 million to the Bureau of Indian Affairs over five years, including $216 million designated for Tribal climate resilience programs. The Inflation Reduction Act of 2022 provided an additional $235 million for Tribal climate

[3]Affiliated Tribes of Northwest Indians (2020) Tribal Review of the Congressional Action Plan on the Climate Crisis. https://atnitribes.org/climatechange/wp-content/uploads/2020/11/ATNI_Tribal-review-of-CAP_11.7.20H.pdf
[4]National Congress of American Indians (2021) NCAI President Fawn Sharp Receives Diplomatic Recognition from United States at COP26. https://www.ncai.org/news/ncai-president-fawn-sharp-receives-diplomatic-recognition-from-united-states-at-cop26
[5]National Congress of American Indians (2021) NCAI President Fawn Sharp Joined World Leaders to Address Climate Change at the White House Leaders Summit on Climate. https://www.ncai.org/news/ncai-president-fawn-sharp-joined-world-leaders-to-address-climate-change-at-the-white-house-leaders-summit-on-climate
[6]World Economic Forum (2023) Leading the Charge Through Earth's New Normal. https://www.weforum.org/meetings/world-economic-forum-annual-meeting-2023/sessions/leading-the-charge-through-earths-new-normal/
[7]U.S. Department of the Interior (2022) Biden-Harris Administration Announces Investments in Tribal Climate Resilience. Available at: https://www.doi.gov/pressreleases

resilience and adaptation efforts[8]. In September 2024, the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency announced $300 million in Climate Pollution Reduction Grants for Tribal Nations[9] and U.S. territories, selecting 34 Tribal and territorial applications for funding. Across the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, the Inflation Reduction Act, and annual appropriations, the Department of the Interior reports that nearly $560 million has been invested in Tribal climate resilience initiatives[10]. A 2020 Bureau of Indian Affairs study estimates that up to $5 billion will be required over the next 50 years to address Tribal infrastructure relocation needs resulting from climate change impacts[11].

Climate Action: A Legacy of Impact

The NCAI Climate Action Task Force has proven that when Tribal Nations organize collectively and bring coordinated strategy to climate policy, the impact reaches every level of governance. Through InterTribal publications that gave leaders actionable frameworks for engaging federal legislation, Congressional testimony that lifted Tribal climate innovations into the national record, and diplomatic engagement that secured Indigenous representation at the highest levels of international climate negotiations, the CATF translated Tribal priorities into policy influence. This was not symbolic participation. It was Tribal Nations exercising sovereignty in climate spaces where Indigenous voices had historically been excluded, and doing so with the analytical rigor and strategic coordination to shift how those spaces operate.

That coordination also moved resources. Federal investment in Tribal climate resilience grew substantially through the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law and the Inflation Reduction Act, directing hundreds of millions of dollars toward Tribal climate adaptation and resilience programs. While this funding remains far below the billions estimated to meet long term Tribal infrastructure and relocation needs driven by climate change, the trajectory reflects what becomes possible when Tribal Nations speak with collective purpose. The CATF demonstrated that empowered Tribal leadership, grounded in broad participation across Indian Country and informed by Indigenous Knowledge, does not just shape climate discourse. It changes where the money goes, who sits at the table, and whose solutions are recognized as models for the path forward.

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[8] U.S. Senate Committee on Indian Affairs (2022) Inflation Reduction Act Resource Guide. https://www.indian.senate.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022-08-16%20(Final)%20SCIA%20IRA%20Resource%20Guide.pdf

[9]U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (2024) Biden-Harris Administration Announces $300 Million in Climate Pollution Reduction Grants for Tribal Nations and U.S. Territories. Available at: https://www.epa.gov/newsreleases

[10]U.S. Department of the Interior (2023) Investments Supporting Tribal Climate Resilience. Available at: https://www.doi.gov/pressreleases

[11]U.S. Department of the Interior (2022) Biden-Harris Administration Makes Commitments to Support Tribal Climate Relocation. Available at: https://www.doi.gov/pressreleases

Conclusion

The NCAI Climate Action Task Force represents the most structured effort in the organization's 80-year history to centralize Tribal climate advocacy. Three insights emerge from this research.

First, the CATF's design reflects NCAI's broader governance philosophy of representing all 574 federally recognized Tribes rather than giving preference to any single region's priorities. Four geographically diverse co-chairs, a 22-member technical committee spanning Elders and youth, and a consensus-driven approach to policy development all signal an intentional architecture. The structure recognizes that **climate action in Indian Country requires both technical expertise and relational legitimacy across Nations with very different geographies, exposures, and governance traditions.**

Second, the Task Force's most consequential outputs were not standalone reports but strategic integration points. Testimony that shaped legislation, diplomatic credentials that opened COP negotiations to Tribal voices, and policy reviews that gave Tribal Leaders ready-made advocacy language for the Congressional Action Plan. These are the kinds of outputs that compound over time. A well-placed testimony or a seat at an international negotiating table creates pathways that outlast any single policy cycle. The CATF functioned less as a traditional committee producing deliverables and more as a connector, translating Tribal climate priorities into language and formats that federal and international institutions could act on.

Third, a significant gap exists between advocacy success and current operational visibility. The CATF page on NCAI's redesigned website shows minimal content, and climate has been less prominent since late 2023. While the CATF remains actively convened, many climate policies, needs, and documentation likely has been folded into broader NCAI policy operations; still, a better understanding of how the mission to "Document, inform, and support the climate action efforts of Tribal nations and Native organizations, and identify and advocate for policies and funding designed to empower their ability to engage in effective, sustainable climate action," is an important question, and one worth asking directly. Institutional knowledge can erode quickly when staffing shifts or leadership priorities change, and the relationships and processes the CATF built are not the kind of thing that transfers automatically.

The resolution and impact record, however, is unambiguous. NCAI has built a documented, consensus-based policy framework on climate stretching back to 2006 that any future task force or advocacy effort can build upon. That framework exists because people did the work of putting Tribal climate priorities into the formal governance record, resolution by resolution, year after year. The infrastructure is there. The question now is who picks it up and what they do with it.